

Now She's
JASON'S
GIRL

EVERYBODY TREATED
MY GIRLFRIEND LIKE HIS

J J V A L E

Now She's Jason's Girl
Everyone treated my girlfriend like his

JJ Vale

PMI

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We packed light because Jason said his suite had everything. He wasn't wrong. When I carried the first load down the basement stairs, I found a queen bed with an actual headboard, a dresser with the tags still on the handles, a small couch angled toward a mounted TV, and a bathroom with folded towels stacked on the edge of the tub like a hotel. It smelled like fresh paint and cedar.

Jenna came down behind me with her duffel over one shoulder and her toiletry bag hugged against her chest. She stood in the middle of the room and turned a slow half-circle, taking it in.

"It's nicer than our old apartment," she murmured.

"Don't tell him that."

She set her bag on the dresser and started pulling things out, arranging them in a specific order, moisturizer, face wash, her little organizer, the same way she arranged them at home. I watched her do it and felt pretty good about fixing our new situation.

We were mostly organized by four, clothes hung or folded, toiletries lined up, her two framed photos propped on the nightstand. She'd brought the one of us at her cousin's wedding and the one of her dog that died two years ago.

Upstairs we could hear Jason moving around, music coming through the floor, something with a low baseline, and the back door opening and closing every few minutes.

We'd been booted from our old apartment and couldn't find another. Jason, the owner of the construction company I used to work for, instantly offered us his basement suite, "at whatever rent you need it to be."

By six the first cars were in the driveway. Jason knocked on the basement door and opened it before either of us answered. He was already in hosting mode, clean white shirt, dark jeans, sleeves pushed to the elbows, holding a set of tongs like a prop.

"Come on up!" he said with his trademark big wide welcoming smile. "People are already starting to show."

The backyard was transformed from what it was four hours ago. String lights were run along the fence line. A folding table held a cooler and two dozen bottles. The grill was going, and people were standing next to it drinking beers.

Jenna had changed into leggings with her oversized cream sweater with the wide neck that she liked pulled to one side to bare a shoulder.

She stayed close to me as more people arrived. I introduced her to people and each time she smiled and said hi and then let the conversation drift around her without joining it.

Jason was in his party mode. He moved through the yard like he'd thrown a hundred of these, which he probably had, shoulder grabs, loud greetings, the kind of laugh that made people near him laugh too.

At some point he came around to where Jenna and I were standing near the fence. He put his hand on her shoulder, one of those steering gestures, casual, and said, "Jenna, you have to meet these two, come here," and walked her three feet to his left before she could even respond.

She glanced back at me and shrugged with a grin. I gestured with my chin for her to just go with it.

And just like that, she was in a conversation.

The barbecue wound down around nine but nobody left. Jason brought out a fire starter and a stack of split wood from beside the garage and within twenty minutes there was a fire-pit going and people pulled the lawn chairs into a loose circle around it.

I ended up on the far side with Julius and a guy named Derek who I'd met before at Jason's old place. They got into it about the upcoming season, the offensive line, the new coordinator, and I fell into it because I knew enough to contribute, at least.

Across the fire I could see Jason's side of the circle. He'd set up chairs, the wide canvas ones with the armrests, and settled into one of them with comfortable and proud ease. I spotted Jenna sitting down in the chair next to him. She still had her cream sweater on and she pulled her knees up, feet tucked under the bottom rung of the chair.

I kept an eye on Jason and Jenna in the gap between Julius and Derek. Jason was telling a story, I could tell by the way his hands moved, wide and

illustrative, and Jenna was watching him with her chin tilted down and a small smile that she gets when she's not sure if something is funny yet but is leaning toward deciding it is.

At the part I assumed was the punchline, where she threw her head back laughing, he reached over and held her wrist. It was just light, the kind of gesture that says *you see what I'm saying*. Jenna laughed full on, and it wasn't just polite either.

I looked back at Derek still going on about formations.

A little later I glanced over and found Jason talking to someone else, but his arm was stretched over the back of Jenna's chair while she talked to the woman on her other side. The woman's name was Britt, I think. Or Brett. Someone's girlfriend.

The fire was lower by eleven. A few people went inside. I was still stuck in a football conversation but I could hear Jason's side of the circle more clearly now.

He was telling Jenna something about the house renovation, the basement specifically, and he touched her shoulder when he said *your place now* and she pulled her sweater over her shoulder and laughed and said something I didn't catch.

"What's funny?" I called over, grinning.

Jenna looked up. "He said he should have put a hot tub down there instead of a couch."

"Still could," Jason said, and pointed the neck of his bottle at me.

I smiled and nodded and Derek said something about the draft and I turned back.

When I looked over again, Jenna's chair was moved a few inches closer to Jason's side. It was a small enough shift that I wasn't certain. The firelight made distances hard to read.

Jason's living room was built for entertaining. The two sectionals alone sat eight people each and he'd angled two additional chairs in from the dining room and there was still a clear sightline to the mounted TV from every seat. By noon there were eleven people in the house and someone had already claimed the corner of the sectional with a blanket like they lived there.

I got in early enough to get a middle seat on the main run of the sectional. Jenna came up from the basement a few minutes after me in joggers and a

fitted long-sleeve, her hair pulled up, minimal makeup. She sat close beside me, her leg against mine, and accepted the bowl of chips someone handed down the row without making eye contact with the person who passed it.

Jason came out of the kitchen carrying two plates of food in one hand and a roll of paper towels under his arm. He distributed things, dropped the paper towels on the coffee table, and took the far corner of the sectional, the wide L-shaped end.

The game started and the room got loud. Julius stood up on the first big play. Someone I didn't know spilled a drink and there was a ten-second chaos of paper towels and laughing. Jenna had her feet tucked under her and was scrolling her phone with the game on in her peripheral.

Around the second quarter Jason said something to the room about the quarterback and then looked directly at Jenna and said, "You watching this or just here for the food?"

She looked up. "Mostly the food," and she shrugged with a cute smile as she reached for a chicken wing and bit it off defiantly at him, with a grin.

"Fair." He laughed then pointed at the screen. "That guy right there is the reason we're losing. Every. Single. Time."

She looked at the screen and then back at him. "Which one?"

"Eleven. Watch eleven."

She watched. A play ran and went nowhere. She made a face, one eyebrow up, and Jason spread his hands like *see* and she laughed and went back to her phone. But she kept it lower this time, glancing up more.

Halftime came and people shifted around. A few went to the kitchen. I got up to use the bathroom, but when I came back someone had taken my seat, one of Julius's friends, already deep in conversation with the guy on my other side. I grabbed one of the chairs pulled in from the dining room and sat on the edge of the group.

Jenna hadn't moved.

But Jason had relocated during the shuffle, closer now to the middle of the sectional, and close to her. He was showing her something on his phone and she was leaning toward it with that same chin-down angle from the fire-pit, lips pressed together like she was deciding whether to react.

And she reacted. She laughed and pushed his arm with the back of her hand.

He said something and held the phone out so she could take it herself. She did and she scrolled something and handed it back.

The second half started but she remained where she was. I watched the game from the chair. At some point she pulled one knee up onto the cushion and turned toward Jason. I saw her lifting her eyes now and then, watching him, checking on him. And when she caught him checking on her, they both grinned a moment before she looked down at her phone with a little blush coming into her cheeks, her grin staying there.

I got the text from Jenna at 2:30 while I was still at my desk finishing a site report. *Jason needed help with the grocery run, hope that's ok, be back before you get home.*

I typed back *no worries* and went back to the report.

She told me about it later that evening while we were getting ready, talking into the mirror while she did her mascara, which itself was odd for a Saturday without us going anywhere specific.

Jason had knocked on the basement door around two and asked if she wanted to ride along to get things for the party. She'd said sure because she'd been sitting on the couch watching nothing in particular and it was something to do.

They took his truck. She said there was country music on the stereo that he turned down when she climbed in.

In the floral section near the entrance he'd grabbed two bunches of sunflowers without breaking stride and handed one to her to carry.

He went back and forth on the appetizer trays in the deli section and asked her which one looked better. She pointed to one and he looked at it for a second and put the other one in the cart and she laughed. He shrugged and said hers might have been the right choice aesthetically but the other one had prosciutto.

She said he kept doing that, asking her opinion and then explaining why he was going a different direction with it, but in a way that didn't feel dismissive, more like he was just thinking out loud and needed a second voice there.

She was still holding the sunflowers when they checked out. Jason pointed at them at the register and said *those are hers*. The cashier bagged them separately.

In the mirror she finished her mascara and started on the other eye. I was sitting on the edge of the bed pulling on my shoes.

"He's so easy to be around," she said to the mirror. "Like it doesn't feel like any effort."

I tied my laces and said, "Yeah, he's like that with everyone."

It was a smaller crowd that evening, maybe eight people total, which I had come to understand was Jason's version of a quiet night, a half-dozen friends and neighbors who showed up around six with bottles of wine and didn't need to be entertained because they'd been coming to his place long enough.

Jenna came upstairs about twenty minutes after I did, and when she came through the sliding glass door onto the patio I noticed she was wearing something different than her usual. It was an off-shoulder sweater, a dusty rose one I'd seen her pack but hadn't seen her wear yet, with her dark fitted jeans. Her hair was down and had some wave worked into it, and she had on enough makeup to be visible without being obvious: a little color on her lips, something across her eyes that made them sit bolder in her face.

I was talking to a man named Greg who lived two streets over and did something in property management, but I watched Jenna cross the patio and take the open chair beside Jason at the far end of the table.

Jason looked up when she sat down and said something to her that I couldn't hear over the music, and she responded with a small, easy smile and reached across to take the wine glass that was already poured in the spot beside him, as though it had been poured for her specifically, which it may well have been.

Greg was asking me something about the renovation work I was doing and pulled my attention back, but I kept Jenna in my peripheral view.

Britt, who I'd seen at the fire-pit gathering, leaned across the table at one point and touched Jenna's wrist and said, loudly enough that I caught it, "You look so good tonight, seriously." Jenna tucked her hair back and said thank you in a way that was genuine without being embarrassed, which was not the way she usually received compliments, which was usually with a deflecting laugh and a subject change.

Later, when people had settled into smaller separate conversations, I watched Julius's girlfriend, a tall woman named Sonia who I'd spoken to before, lean toward her husband and say something while glancing in Jenna's direction. Julius nodded without looking up from his drink, and

Sonia watched Jenna for another moment with the patient, assessing expression of someone confirming something they'd already decided.

Jason had his arm along the back of Jenna's chair again and was telling a story to the group. Jenna was listening with her chin resting in one hand and her elbow on the table. She was angled toward him in a way that made them look, from the other end of the patio table, like they had arrived together.

Or that's just how I was feeling about things.

I woke up around twelve-thirty because the music upstairs shifted to something slower and quieter and the change in sound pulled me out of sleep the way silence sometimes does. I'd been too tired and went down to bed, but Jenna wasn't ready yet, and stayed up.

She still wasn't in bed now. I lay there for a moment looking at the ceiling, then got up and went to the bathroom and then decided I was going to go upstairs.

The living room was dark except for the kitchen light spilling through the doorway. I could hear water running and then stopping, and low music, but especially Jenna's laugh, a very specific one that comes out shorter and more surprised.

I came around the corner into the kitchen.

Jason was standing with his back mostly to me, one hand on the counter edge. Jenna was sitting on the counter itself, barefoot, her legs dangling, the off-shoulder sweater off both shoulders, and very short skirt. Jason was standing close enough that her knees were on either side of him and he was saying something to her face from maybe ten inches away and she was looking at him with her head tilted back, still coming down from whatever she'd been laughing at.

Neither of them heard me come in.

"That's not even the worst part," Jason said softly to her

"What's the worst part." I saw her eyes watching not his eyes, but his mouth.

"The worst part is I had already paid for the ticket."

Jenna pressed her lips together and shook her head and then laughed again, shorter this time. "That's so bad," she said, her eyes flaring and bright.

"It was a non-refundable situation."

"How much."

"Enough that I still think about it."

She was looking at him with both hands flat on the counter on either side of her legs. There was nobody left, nobody else around. I stood in the doorway for a second longer before I moved enough that the floor creaked under me. Jason turned around first.

"Hey," he said, easy, no shift in posture. "Thought you were out for the count."

"Came up," I said.

Jenna looked over his shoulder at me. "We were just finishing the dishes." She gestured at the dishwasher, which had a stack of plates in it and two large serving bowls. They didn't move away from each other.

I went to the cabinet and got a glass and filled it at the sink. Jason moved to the side to give me access to the faucet, which put him at the corner of the counter rather than directly in front of Jenna, but she stayed where she was, still sitting up on the counter with her feet swinging.

"Good party," I said.

"Greg and Sonia are good people," Jason said. "You talk to Greg much?"

"A little. Property management stuff."

"He's got three buildings over in the east end. Keeps telling me he wants to renovate all of them." He shook his head. "Three buildings is a lot of tile."

Jenna was watching us talk with her hands on the counter beside her.

I drank the glass of water and set it on the edge of the sink.

"I'm heading back down," I said.

"I'll be down soon," Jenna said.

Jason was already turning back toward the cabinet, reaching up to put a serving bowl away on the high shelf, and Jenna watched him reach for it with her chin raised, not helping, even though he had to reach up and over her head, his chest nearly in her face.

It started because of the lighting. That was what she said when she mentioned it to me Friday evening, as a logistical observation. The basement bathroom had one fixture above the mirror and it cast everything yellow and downward, which made it hard to do makeup accurately. Jason's upstairs bathroom had the big vanity with the Hollywood-style bulbs running along both sides of the mirror, the kind of setup where you could actually see what you were doing.

Jason had told her at some point during the week, casually, that she was welcome to use it whenever she needed to. She mentioned this the same way she mentioned the grocery run, in passing, as a passing fact.

So on Sunday afternoon, about ninety minutes before people started arriving, she took her makeup bag and her outfit for the evening upstairs and got ready in Jason's bathroom instead.

I was on the couch in the basement watching something on my laptop when I heard her and Jason talking upstairs. It wasn't the words, just the rhythm of it, his voice, then hers, then his, an easy back and forth without pauses. They had conversation that had found its pace.

I came up around four-thirty to get a drink. The upstairs bathroom door was open. Jenna was at the vanity with her hair down around her shoulders, working something through the ends of it with a round brush. She had on her dark jeans already and a bra, her top not yet on. She'd done her foundation and eyes but not her lips yet. The vanity lights made her skin look warm and even.

Jason was in the hallway just outside the open door, leaning against the wall with his arms crossed, talking to her reflection in the mirror the way people do when they're having a conversation through a doorway.

He looked over when I came up the stairs and nodded. "Your girl cleans up real good," he said, and he laughed.

"Yeah," I said.

Jenna met my eyes in the mirror and went back to the brush.

Jason watched her work the brush through the ends of her hair for a moment and said, "You should wear it down more. The up thing is fine but down is better on you."

Jenna looked at her own reflection, tilting her head. "You think so."

"Hundred percent," he said, like it was a straightforward fact he was confirming rather than an opinion he was offering.

She set the brush on the vanity and looked at herself for another moment and then picked up her lip liner and leaned toward the mirror.

She didn't seem to think it was an issue to be dressed in only her bra up in Jason's bathroom, him right outside the door chatting with her.

I got a drink from the kitchen and stood in the hallway for a moment. Jason had shifted his shoulder against the wall to face more into the bathroom. Jenna was leaning toward the mirror with her lips parted, drawing the liner along her upper lip in a slow careful line.

I went back downstairs.

Her hair was down by the time people arrived.

Jason ran poker nights the way he ran everything, with enough structure to feel organized and enough looseness that it didn't matter if you didn't know what you were doing. Two tables, eight players each, buy-in was casual enough that losing didn't sting but winning felt like something. He had actual chips in a case with a felt lining and a dealer button that got passed around the table and someone always ended up learning the rules mid-hand from whoever was sitting next to them.

Jenna said she didn't really know poker when we came upstairs. Jason said that was fine and pulled out the chair beside his and said she could watch a few hands and pick it up.

I took a seat at the second table with Julius and two guys I recognized from the football Sundays. The tables were close enough that I had a sightline to the main table without turning around, but watching it directly meant turning my back to my own hand, which I did more than I should have.

Jason explained the hierarchy of hands to Jenna in the first round, leaning toward her with his cards fanned and pointing at them while he talked. She watched his hand rather than her own. He folded early and used the time between hands to keep explaining, burn cards, pot odds, when to read the table rather than the cards. She asked a few questions and he answered them in the same direction, toward her ear, close enough that she'd hear his soft murmuring clearly over the noise in the room.

His arm was around her shoulders.

By the fifth or sixth hand she was playing her own cards with him advising. He'd glance at her hand when she picked it up and make a small expression, a slight raise of his eyebrows or a press of his lips, that she was learning to read. When she won a small pot he spread his hands toward the chips and said *there you go* and the table reacted and she pulled the chips toward her with both hands and laughed at the size of her own reaction.

I was getting beaten badly at my table because I wasn't concentrating on it.

I got knocked out around ten and came to stand behind the main table with a drink. Jason's left hand was resting Jenna's back. At some point, his hand came off the table and settled on her thigh just above the knee,

casually, the way someone rests a hand when they need somewhere to put it and the surface nearest to them happens to be there.

Jenna didn't look down. She was looking at her cards with the focused, overdone expression of someone still performing concentration while actually starting to feel it naturally.

Someone across the table made a joke and the table laughed and Jason's hand stayed where it was through the laughter, through the next deal, through Jenna folding and leaning back in the chair into the space his arm had been holding open behind her. She turned to him and murmured something I couldn't hear and smiled with glowing eyes.

Someone brought out a phone on a tripod stand around seven, which was the kind of thing that happens at Jason's gatherings.

The pool was open for the first time that season and there were probably eighteen people in the backyard. Jenna had on a white eyelet top with thin straps and her dark jeans and sandals. She'd done her hair down the way Jason had mentioned he liked it and added something to it that gave it more volume than usual. She was standing with Britt and Sonia near the pool steps when the tripod came out.

Jason organized the first group shot the way he organized most things, not by announcing it but by simply positioning himself where the photo would happen and pulling people toward him until there were enough. He reached out and caught Jenna's wrist as she was passing behind him and said, "Get in here," and she came without breaking stride, stepping into the space beside him at the center of the frame.

The photo was taken. Then another because someone blinked. Then Julius made a face and it came a third time.

Britt wanted individual pairings after that. She went around the group pointing at combinations, *you two, now you three, come here you*, directing with her wine glass. When she got to Jason she pointed at him and then swept her finger around in a small circle that landed on Jenna and said, "Obviously."

Jason put his arm around Jenna's shoulders for the photo. She leaned into it, naturally, with her hand coming up to rest at the center of his chest the way people do when an arm comes around them and they need somewhere to put their hand.

Britt looked at the screen and turned it around. "Look at that. That's a Christmas card."

A few people leaned in to look. Someone said *seriously* and someone else laughed. Jenna looked at the photo from where she was standing, still within the loose bracket of Jason's arm, and said, "That's a good one actually."

"You two are ridiculous," Sonia said, but she was smiling when she said it, the kind of comment that functions as a compliment about how well something looks rather than a criticism of what it means.

I was standing at the grill end of the patio and Greg handed me his phone to take a photo of him and his wife. I took three and handed it back and when I looked up Jason was showing Jenna something on his phone with his head bent toward hers, and Jenna was looking at the screen with one hand shading it against the low sun.

Britt caught me standing alone and said, "Chris, get in one," and pointed at the space beside Jason on the other side from Jenna.

I walked over and the three of us stood there for the photo and Britt counted to three. In the photo, Jenna isn't looking at the camera. Her attention was grabbed just as the photo was taken, and she's looking sideways off screen with a "wow" look and eyes wide open.

The concert was someone's idea from three weeks back and had grown the way Jason's plans always grew, from four people to six to eleven, and by the time the Saturday arrived there were fourteen of them meeting at the house before heading downtown together.

People started arriving at seven. I was already upstairs when Jenna came up from the basement, and I heard her before I saw her because her shoes were different, a heeled platform sandal with a thin strap across the ankle that made a specific sound on the hardwood stairs.

She had on black jeans that were tighter than anything I'd seen her wear, and a silky sleeveless top in a dark burgundy. Her hair was down with the volume she'd been adding lately. The eyeliner was heavier than the patio night, a definite line rather than a suggestion, and her lips had gloss on them that caught the kitchen light when she turned her head, lips relaxed apart. She was looking like someone else entirely.

Jason looked over from across the kitchen island where he was pouring drinks and said, "There she is."

Jenna set her small bag on the counter and said, "Am I late?"

"You're right on time," he said, and handed her a glass.

People were spread across the kitchen and living room, volume already up, the playlist running loud through the speakers. I was talking to Julius near the window and watched Jason come around the island and stand in front of Jenna and look at her with that openly assessing expression he used when he was deciding something.

"Turn around," he said.

She gave him a look. "Why."

"Just turn around."

She turned slowly one full rotation, holding her drink out to the side for balance. Someone nearby whistled and Jenna laughed and faced forward again.

Jason reached out and adjusted the strap of her top on her left shoulder, pulling it a half-inch toward the neckline. "That was off," he said.

"It wasn't bothering me."

"It was bothering me." He looked at the neckline for a second and then at her face. "You need earrings."

"I don't have any that work with this."

He didn't hesitate. "Britt has some here, go ask her."

Jenna looked at him for a moment with a sly grin and then picked up her glass and went to find Britt.

I came over to the island and poured myself a drink. Jason was looking at his phone, scrolling something, thumb moving fast.

"She looks good," I said.

He looked up. "She always looks good," he said, in the tone of someone correcting a minor factual error, and went back to his phone.

Jenna came back ten minutes later with small gold hoops in her ears. Jason looked up when she came back into the kitchen and nodded definitively, like something had been resolved.

"Much better," he said.

"Britt said I can keep them," Jenna said.

"Yeah?" He handed her a fresh drink. "Okay, fifteen minutes and we're loading up."

She took the drink and turned to find me in the kitchen and smiled when she spotted me, bright and easy, and she pulled her hair back as though to show me her new earrings, as though to make me jealous or something.

I wasn't going to the concert. It wasn't my thing.

The bed was empty at seven-fifteen the next morning and I came upstairs because I had a work call at eight and needed to eat something and we had nothing. The house was quiet.

The kitchen light was on. I could smell coffee and something on the pan before I came around the corner.

Jenna was at the kitchen island on one of the high stools, both hands around a mug, her hair loose and uncombed from sleep. She had on small cotton shorts, the kind she wore to bed, pale grey. On top she had a white t-shirt that wasn't hers, I could tell by the fit of it, the way it sat across her shoulders wider.

It was Jason's. Jason was at the stove with his back to both of us, in joggers and no shirt, moving something around in a pan. A cutting board with a halved avocado on it sat beside the stove. The coffee maker was running.

Jenna looked up when I came in. "Hey. You want coffee?"

"Yeah," I said.

She got down from the stool and went to the cabinet and got a mug the way she did at home, the way you do when you know someone's habits. She poured it and set it on the island.

Jason turned around. "Eggs?" he said, looking at me.

"Yeah sure," I said.

He turned back to the stove and cracked two more into the pan. Jenna got back onto the stool and pulled her mug toward her and looked at the countertop in that half-awake look she has before the first coffee is finished.

I stood at the island across from her and drank mine.

"What time did you two get in?" I said.

"Late," she said. "Like after two."

I had been asleep when they got back. I vaguely recalled half awaking when Jenna came into our bedroom but I must have fallen back asleep before she got in bed.

"Good night?"

"Really good," she said, and she smiled into her mug.

Jason slid eggs onto a plate and brought it around the island and set it in front of her first, then went back for mine. Jenna pulled the plate toward her and picked up her fork.

Jason brought my plate and set it across the island and went back and got his own and leaned against the counter beside the stove to eat rather than sitting, the way he did when his mind was already on the next thing.

The t-shirt on Jenna had a small logo on the left chest faded from washing. She ate her eggs with both elbows on the island and her hair falling forward on one side and didn't push it back.

Jason rented the projector from somewhere and set it up on a folding table at the back of the yard, pointing it at a white sheet he'd strung between two of the fence posts with some kind of tension cord system that kept it flat enough to be a workable screen. It was a Saturday in early October, cool enough that people came out with blankets and the fire was going in the pit off to the side for warmth.

There were about twelve people over. Someone dragged the outdoor sectional pieces away from the patio and arranged them in a loose arc facing the sheet, and the remaining seating was a combination of lawn chairs, folded quilts on the ground, and the wide outdoor chaise that Jason usually kept along the side of the pool.

I came out carrying two blankets from downstairs and a bowl of popcorn Jenna had made on the stove in Jason's large pot. She was already outside. I came through the sliding door and looked for her and found her standing beside the chaise with Jason, looking at the projected image on the sheet while Jason adjusted the focus with a small remote. The image sharpened and someone across the yard said something approving.

I set one blanket down on a section of the outdoor sofa nearest the fire where Julius and Sonia already were, put the popcorn on the armrest, and carried the second blanket toward the chaise.

By the time I got there Jenna was already sitting on it, legs out, her back against the angled upper section. Jason sat down on the same chaise from the other end, also legs out, and reached to the side where he had his own blanket already waiting on the ground, which he shook out over both of them in one motion without asking or pausing.

Jenna pulled her side of the blanket up to her waist and settled back.

I stood there for a moment with the second blanket in my hands.

Julius called over from the sofa section, "Chris, get in here, we need the body heat", and laughed, and Sonia moved over to make space. I looked at

the chaise and then at the sofa section and went to where there was room. Obviously.

The movie started. It was something with subtitles that Jason had picked and that three people complained about for the first five minutes. The fire crackled off to the left and the projected image was bright enough that the yard felt contained, like its own small theater.

I watched the movie but I also watched the chaise in my peripheral the way I'd been watching things in my peripheral for weeks.

Jenna said something to Jason early in the film, leaning toward him under the shared blanket. He responded without taking his eyes off the screen, and she settled back. Later she shifted her position and ended up with her shoulder against his arm and he adjusted his arm to accommodate her, lifting it and letting it come down around her side of the blanket.

The popcorn bowl sat on the armrest between them and they reached into it at intervals.

It wasn't discussed beforehand, and it wasn't talked about after, either.

Jason sent a text to a group thread at ten in the morning that said *pool's open, bring bodies* and by one o'clock there were twenty-three people in the backyard.

The catering setup was on the patio, trays covered in foil, a guy Jason knew running the grill, two coolers packed under the table with the good drinks and one open cooler on the far end for whatever people brought themselves. Music came through the outdoor speakers loud enough to feel it near the pool but not so loud you couldn't talk over it.

I was in board shorts and a t-shirt, which I eventually took off, standing near the grill end of the patio with Greg and a man named Terrence who did something in commercial lending and was trying to get Jason interested in a project. I was half in the conversation and half watching the pool, where most people had migrated.

Jenna came out of the house in a black bikini. Jason had taken her to the mall four days earlier. She mentioned it the way she mentioned the grocery run, factually, in passing, said he told her she needed something that actually fit "her new station in life.". She came home with two bags and showed me the bikini in the basement, holding it up on its hanger. It was small and black with thin ties at the hips and a top that did its job without

much margin. She said Jason picked it off the rack and told her to try it. He paid for it, so why not, she said with a shrug.

Standing on the patio it seemed to fit the way he said it would. Tight.

She dropped her towel on one of the chairs and went to the pool edge and sat and eased herself in. Jason was already in the water, chest-deep near the side, talking to Julius and another man whose name I didn't know. He turned when Jenna entered and moved a few feet toward her without stopping what he was saying.

The configuration in the pool had settled into something loose and social, people in clusters, drinks on the pool edge, the volume up. I watched from the patio, beer in hand, still with Greg and Terrence talking at me.

Jenna was sitting on the pool edge now at the deep end, legs in the water. Jason stood in the pool in front of her facing outward, his back against the wall between her knees, talking to two men across from him, the commercial lending conversation having migrated to the pool. His arms were over her knees and out along the pool edge to either side, completely relaxed, and Jenna's legs were loosely around his torso, her heels spurring into his ribs.

Her right hand moved along the back of his neck slowly, fingers going into his wet hair and then back down, the kind of absent, repetitive motion you do when your hand needs somewhere to be and the surface it finds is familiar. She was playing in his hair and he was largely ignoring it. She was looking across the pool at Britt and Sonia on the opposite edge, and Jason was talking about load-bearing walls to the two men in front of him. Neither of them was paying attention to Jenna's hand, and in fact nobody nearby was reacting to any of it.

Julius leaned over the edge near them and said something to Jason that made Jason laugh, a short loud one, and Jenna's hand paused during the laugh and then resumed after it, her smiling absently.

I put my empty bottle in the recycling bin beside the patio table.

Terrence was explaining interest rate structures and Greg was nodding and I turned back toward them and nodded too and Terrence kept going.

Behind me the music switched to something with more bass and someone in the pool made a sound of approval. Jenna sat up straighter, arched her back in and pulled on Jason's temples so that his head came back to rest on her belly. She massaged his temples and leaned over and down far enough to whisper something in his ear.

I found her later by the bbq eating a burger. "Getting pretty close to him," I said.

"Sorry?"

"Jason."

"He's so nice to us, isn't he?" she said, her dark lined eyes looking up to me warm and deep. "Let's us come to all his parties, let's us have whatever food we can find in his kitchen."

"Yeah, he's pretty good that way. Saw you massaging his head," I said and I chuckled.

She considered her burger. "He loves that."

"It's just..." I started but she spun toward me and burst out laughing.

"Oh my god! You don't think...!" Then she gasped and covered her mouth. "You do!" and she slapped my shoulder. "Now look who's being ridiculous," she said, and she held her burger up for me to bite from.

She dabbed her finger at the corner of my mouth at the ketchup there. "I am pretty sure you don't have to worry. Would I be doing anything right in front of you if there was?"

I chewed my bite and she looked closely at it again for her next bite. "We're just playing with it," she said casually. "We're just teasing each other about it. He's just a big silly goof-ball."

The plan was eight o'clock but getting ready started at six, which meant the upstairs bathroom was occupied by four-forty-five. Britt and Sonia were already up there when I came upstairs to get a drink, the door open, music playing from someone's phone propped on the edge of the tub, the counter covered in the specific spread of products that appears when more than one woman shares a mirror.

Jenna was in the bathroom chair with Sonia standing behind her doing something to her hair with a large round brush and a diffuser. Britt was at the mirror doing her own face, talking to Jenna's reflection. I could never keep straight who Britt and Sonia were girlfriends to, Terrance and Greg? Greg and Terrance?

I leaned in the doorway. Jenna had on a robe she'd borrowed Jason. Her face was already done, foundation, contour, something dramatic around her eyes that I didn't have vocabulary for but that made her look like someone I recognized from a show.

"You need anything?" I said.

"We're good," Britt said, without turning around.

Jenna met my eyes in the mirror and smiled. "Jason said we're leaving at ten sharp."

"He always says sharp," Sonia said and she rolled her eyes.

I went downstairs and watched television for a while and heard them moving around upstairs, the music switching, laughter at intervals, the particular sound of women getting ready in a group.

Around eight-thirty Jason's footsteps crossed the kitchen above me. Then voices, his joining the bathroom sounds, then a pause.

I came upstairs.

Jason was in the hallway outside the bathroom in dark trousers and a fitted black shirt, holding a white shopping bag. Britt was leaning against the doorframe. Jenna was still in the robe, hair finished now, falling in smooth sections past her shoulders.

Jason reached into the bag and pulled out a dress on a thin hanger. It was cream-colored, very short, with a low back and a neckline that crossed in the front. He held it up by the hanger in Jenna's direction.

"Try this," he said.

Jenna looked at the dress and then at him. "Where did you get that."

"I was passing the boutique on Fourth when I picked up the car." He held it higher, presenting it. "It'll look unbelievable on you."

Britt looked at the dress and then at Jenna and said, "Oh you have to."

Jenna reached out and took the hanger and looked at the dress up close, turning it once. Then Jason reached back into the bag and came out with a shoebox and handed that over too. She took the lid off and inside were cream-colored platform pumps with an ankle strap.

"Jason," she said, looking at the shoes.

"Just try them," he said.

Sonia was already closing the bathroom door from the inside, pulling Jenna in with her. "Everyone out," she said through the closing gap, laughing.

Jason turned and walked back toward the kitchen with the empty bag, unhurried, rolling his left shirt sleeve to the elbow and then his right.

"She's going to look so fucking hot," he said to me in passing. "Your girlfriend."

I stood in the hallway outside the closed bathroom door.

The music inside switched to something faster.

The party started at eight and Jason always opened the front door himself for the first hour, which I had come to understand was a specific thing he did rather than a habit, a way of setting the energy at the threshold.

I was in the kitchen making a drink when the first guests arrived and heard his voice go up at the door, the particular register he used for greetings, wide and warm and already laughing before the other person had said anything funny.

When I came through to the living room Jenna was standing beside him at the door.

She had the cream dress on and the platform heels added three inches and changed the geometry of how she stood, weight back, shoulders naturally pulled straighter. Her hair was down and smooth the way Sonia had finished it. She had on Britt's gold hoops again, or a pair like them.

Jason had his arm loosely around her waist while he talked to the couple coming in, a man named Paul and his girlfriend whose name I heard as Cara, and Jenna was saying something to Cara about her jacket, reaching out to touch the sleeve of it. Cara was already turned toward her, already more interested in talking to Jenna than in whatever Paul and Jason were working through about a job site.

I moved through to the living room and started a conversation with Julius, who was already there with a drink and the particular settled look of someone who arrived early and intends to stay late.

Over the next forty minutes I watched the door from across the room.

People came in in pairs and small groups and the pattern repeated with minor variations. Jason would open the door and the greeting would come and then Jenna with Jason's hand at her back steering her forward, or by the guests themselves, who had begun orienting toward her the way people orient toward whoever is standing closest to the host.

A man named Garrett came in with two women I didn't recognize and he shook Jason's hand and then turned to Jenna and kissed her cheek and said, "You look incredible." Jenna received it with the easy, un-deflecting smile she'd been developing over the last few weeks, and said, "So do you, I love this," and touched the lapel of his jacket. Garrett said something back and they were already in a conversation before Jason had finished greeting the two women.

I watched a couple I'd never seen before arrive and be introduced to Jenna. She shook the woman's hand and the woman held onto it for a

second and said, "Oh, you must be Jenna, Jason talks about you," and Jenna smiled and said something I couldn't hear over the music.

Julius said something to me and I turned back.

Later I went to get another drink and passed through the entryway and Jason caught my arm as I went by. He said, "You good?" in the way that's a greeting rather than a question.

"Yeah," I said. "All good."

He nodded and turned back to the door and Jenna glanced at me once over the shoulder of whoever she was talking to and then back to the conversation in front of her.

Derek needed help getting his truck unstuck from the soft patch of ground beside the side gate where he'd parked without realizing the drainage from the pool filter ran underneath it. We spent about twenty minutes with a floor mat under the back tire and Derek's engine complaining before it finally got enough grip to pull out, and by then my shoes were muddy. Derek owed me a beer that he produced from his truck cab.

The garage side door was open when we came around the front of the house. Light spilled out onto the driveway in a wide rectangle. I could hear Jason's voice from inside before I could see anything.

I stopped at the open door.

The garage was half-workshop, half-storage, Jason's truck usually parked on the left side, the right side given over to a workbench that ran the full length of the wall, pegboard above it hung with tools in the specific organized way of someone who used them regularly. Samples of materials leaned against the wall in grouped rows, tile, hardwood, laminate, and there were rolled plans and flat plans both on the bench and tacked to a corkboard above it.

Jenna was standing at the workbench looking at a spread of something flat, blueprints or drawings, I couldn't see clearly from the door. She had on joggers and a cropped sweatshirt, her hair up, no shoes, which meant she came out here from inside the house without planning to stay.

Jason stood directly behind her, close enough that the front of his shirt touched her back, both his hands resting along her waist, thumbs near her spine. He was looking over her shoulder at the plans on the bench and

talking in the even, explanatory tone he used when he was describing a project he was genuinely interested in.

"The whole back wall comes out," he said. "Once that load is transferred you get an extra fourteen feet going straight into what used to be the utility room and the whole thing becomes one continuous space."

Jenna was looking at the drawing nodding slowly. "So this is where we are now," she said, pointing at something.

"Right there. And this ..." he moved one hand from her waist to reach past her and indicate a section of the drawing, "... is what it becomes. Open plan, twelve-foot ceilings, skylights along here."

His hand came back to her waist when he finished pointing.

"That's a big difference," she said.

"That's the job," he said.

She reached out and picked up a wood sample from the row on the bench, a darker stained piece, wide grain, and turned it over in her hands. "This one?"

"That's the flooring option for the main space. Feel the weight of it."

She bounced it in her palm. "Heavy."

"Engineered hardwood. It's got a real wood veneer over the composite so it behaves like hardwood but doesn't move with humidity." His hands were still on her waist, not moving, just resting there. "Run your thumb across the grain."

She did. Then she set it back down and picked up a lighter piece beside it.

"That's the secondary option," he said. "Cheaper. Looks it too."

"I like the first one more."

"Me too," he said. "Client wants to see both so we show them both."

Derek appeared at the door beside me and leaned in and said, "Jace, you got an extra level I can borrow?"

Jason looked up over Jenna's head. "Top shelf, far left, behind the clamps."

Derek went in. I stayed at the door. Jason looked back down at the plans and said something else to Jenna about the window placement and she leaned forward to look at where he was indicating and his hands adjusted with the lean without lifting.

She bent over in front of him and he didn't move back, but rather allowed his hips to press into her back end, holding onto her hips. She came down

on her elbows over the blueprints in front of her. He casually gathered her hair in his hands, pulling it up and out of her line of sight.

I saw her back arch down. I saw him hold her hair, tug it, and I saw her push her ass backward into his hips. I saw all of that.

The gathering that night was the kind that assembles without a specific occasion, a Friday that happened to have good weather, enough people free, and Jason's house as the default answer to the question of where to go. By nine o'clock there were sixteen or seventeen people distributed across the main floor, some outside on the patio, most inside with the sliding doors open so the two spaces functioned as one.

I'd been outside with Greg and a man named Stu who worked in commercial roofing and had a running disagreement with Jason about flashing technique that apparently went back two years and got relitigated at every gathering. I liked Stu. He was straightforward and funny and didn't care whether you agreed with him.

Jason came outside around nine-thirty and got into it with Stu, the way they always did, and it was genuinely entertaining for about ten minutes before someone pulled Jason back inside for something.

I followed him in a few minutes later to get a drink.

The kitchen had four or five people in it, the island covered in bottles and glasses and the remains of the appetizer from earlier. The conversation was loud and general. Someone was telling a story about a flight delay that had gotten progressively more elaborate each time I'd heard a piece of it that evening.

Jason was at the far end of the island, facing me and the rest of the kitchen, leaning back against the counter that ran along the back wall. He was in the conversation with the flight delay group, contributing occasionally, his expression easy and engaged.

Jenna stood directly in front of him with her back to his chest. She had on a thin ribbed top, pale yellow, and the dark jeans she wore to the concert. Her arms were at her sides loosely.

I got to the island and poured a drink and looked up and registered that Jason's arms were around her from behind and then looked again before I understood what I was seeing.

His hands were inside the front of her top.

And not at the hem either, nor at the waist. His hands were up and forward, inside the fabric, and the shape of them was visible through the thin ribbed material, the outline clear enough that there was no reading it differently.

Jenna stood with her weight back against him and her eyes occupied by the flight delay story, her expression attentive, following the conversation. A faint color sat along her cheekbones that wasn't makeup. When the story got to a punchline she smiled at it, the kind that reaches her eyes, and when she did she glanced sideways rather than directly at anyone, a small inward thing.

She didn't look at me.

Jason caught me walking in, I must have said something about Stu, something about the flashing argument, and he responded over her head in his normal register, making a point about membrane underlayment, completely in the conversation, his expression unchanged.

I stood at the island facing them, his hands remaining inside my girlfriend's top high enough up.

The flight delay story wrapped up and people reacted and someone started a related story. Jenna's eyes moved to the new speaker. She reached up with one hand and tucked a piece of hair behind her ear, her elbow covering the front of her shirt, and then her arm came back down.

Jason said something to me about Stu that was mildly insulting in the affectionate way he talked about people he liked and I responded and we had three or four exchanges about it while the loud kitchen conversation ran around us.

At some point I looked at Jenna again and her eyes were looking at me for a second. Then she looked back at the person talking.

I finished pouring my drink and picked it the glass.

Maybe it was the light, the shadows, just the way the top fit on her.

The plan for getting home was loose the way end-of-night plans always are, people splitting into cars based on who was nearest, who had space, who was heading which direction. Julius had his truck and took three people including Greg. Stu called a car. Britt and Sonia went with Paul and Cara.

Jason had his SUV and was driving because that was how he operated on nights out, present at the party without being in it the same way everyone

else was, which gave him the car at the end of the night.

Jenna ended up in Jason's SUV.

The way it happened was simple and quick. I was talking to Derek about something when I registered it. There was a small reorganization at the front of the club as groups assembled and I heard Jason say something to Jenna about the SUV having the heated seats and she laughed and went with him and then Derek said something that required a response and I turned to him.

I ended up in Derek's car with two people whose names I'd been given twice that evening and still didn't know. Derek drove carefully and slowly the way people do when they want you to know they are fine to drive. The ride took about forty-five minutes because of a road closure that pushed us through a much longer route full of traffic.

Jason's SUV was already in the driveway when we pulled up. The front door of the house was open, light coming through the screen door.

I thanked Derek and went up the front walk.

Through the screen door I could see into the entryway and the start of the hallway. I heard Jenna laughing before I got the door open, a real, unguarded laugh, the loose kind that only comes out when someone is both happy and tired.

I opened the door.

Jenna was in the hallway, barefoot, carrying both heels in her left hand by the ankle straps, the platform soles swinging. Her dress was still intact, but there was something relaxed in how she wore it now, the way clothes settle differently at two in the morning. Her hair had the soft dishevelment of a full night out. Her makeup had lasted but softened at the edges.

Jason was beside her with his right hand at her hip, not gripping, just present, the steadying contact of someone who has been doing it for a while. They were moving toward the kitchen and she was still coming down from the laugh, pressing her lips together against the tail end of it.

She saw me come in and said, "Hey, you," and held the heels up in explanation of their absence like I'd asked about them.

"Good ride back?" I said.

"He knows every back road in the city," she said, and looked at Jason when she said it. "No hold up for us."

"Derek get you back okay?" Jason said.

"Long way around," I said. "Road closure on Fifth."

"Yeah I knew that." He moved past Jenna toward the kitchen. "Water?"

"Sure," I said.

Jenna leaned against the hallway wall and bent one knee up to look at the bottom of her foot, then the other one. "The sidewalk outside was disgusting," she said.

Jason came back with two glasses and handed one to her first. She took it and drank most of it standing there in the hallway, barefoot, the heels still in her other hand, hip against the wall.

He watched her drink it with the patience.

"Why are your shoes off anyway?" I said.

"They came off in Jason's car."

I laughed and squinted. "They came off?"

"Jason didn't want them on the seat."

I came upstairs at six-fifteen to find my watch, which I'd left on the kitchen counter two days earlier and hadn't needed until now. The party was at seven and I was already dressed, dark jeans, button-down, the usual, and I wanted the watch because it was a nice enough occasion to bother with it.

The watch was on the counter where I left it. I picked it up and heard voices from the upstairs bathroom, the door mostly closed this time rather than open the way it usually was when Jenna got ready. A thin bar of vanity light showed at the bottom of the door.

I started back toward the stairs and the bathroom door opened.

Jason came out first, or half out, leaning back through the doorway. He had on charcoal trousers and a dark navy shirt, jacket not yet on. He was holding something small between his thumb and forefinger and I couldn't make it out from the hallway.

"Come here, turn around," he said, back into the bathroom.

Jenna appeared in the doorframe. She had on a short dark dress, navy or black, the hallway light made it hard to tell, with a low back and a hem that ended several inches above her knee. There were platform heels again, cream ones from the boutique, which looked different against the dark dress, deliberately contrasting. Her hair was up this time, gathered at the back of her neck in a way that left her shoulders and the top of her back exposed.

She turned around and faced the mirror rather than the door, her back to Jason.

He held up what was in his hand and I could see it then, a necklace, a thin gold chain with something at the center, a small pendant or stone, catching the vanity light when it moved. He reached around from behind her and brought both ends of the chain to her collarbone and worked the clasp at the back of her neck with both hands, his chin lowered toward the top of her head to see what he was doing.

It took him maybe fifteen seconds to fasten it.

Jenna looked at herself in the mirror. She raised one hand and touched the pendant at the center of the chain with her index finger, lifting it and letting it settle. She turned her chin left and right, looking.

"Jason," she said.

"Don't," he said, meaning the thank you that was coming.

She looked at herself for another moment. Then she reached up and adjusted a small piece of hair at her temple, smoothing it back.

Jason met his own eyes in the mirror and then looked at her and said, "Okay, that's the one," in the manner of someone confirming a decision they made before the dress went on.

I was standing in the hallway with my watch in my hand.

Neither of them looked toward the door, which was open maybe eight inches, enough to see the mirror and both of them in it. The hallway was dark relative to the vanity lights and I was standing back from the frame.

Jenna turned from the mirror to face Jason and he put both hands on her bare upper arms and looked at her once, directly, the way someone looks when they want to see something whole before an evening starts, and then dropped his hands and turned to get his jacket from the bed.

That's when Jenna saw me in the hallway. "Just a necklace," she said with a shrug. "I'm not keeping it."

"For tonight then?"

"Just for the party. Jason wanted me to."

"I thought maybe we could talk a bit first, like downstairs."

"I don't think we have time," she said with a sympathetic curve of her eyebrows.

"It's just, shoes, dresses, now necklaces. I mean..."

She came out and pressed her pointing finger into my stomach. "He was your friend, buster!" she said with a laugh, and she nearly kissed me on the tip of my nose. "Maybe talk to him if you want him to control himself. Me?" she said, and she twirled in front of me. "It's hardly my fault if men

lose their minds when I come in the room,” she said and she laughed with a squeal and headed to the kitchen.

It was something Jason has said to her a lot of times, some line from some old time song.

The temperature dropped faster that evening and by nine o'clock the patio heaters were all running and people were gathered in tighter clusters around them. It was the tail end of October, a gathering to celebrate Paul and Cara's renovation project that Jason had just finished, which meant the guest list was different from the usual crowd, some of the same people, but some new faces from Paul's side, a few couples I recognized and more that I didn't.

I was standing near the heater closest to the house wall with a man named Frank who was a contractor out of the east end and had worked with Jason on two commercial jobs. He was easy to talk to in the way that people who are good at their work are easy to talk to. He had opinions and evidence for them and wasn't interested in performing expertise he didn't have.

Jason had pulled two of the wide patio chairs close to the central heater at the far end of the patio and was sitting in one of them talking to Paul and a man whose name I heard as Desmond, who apparently owned three or four commercial properties that Jason was considering pitching.

Jenna had come outside about twenty minutes after I did, in a wide ribbed turtleneck sweater, oatmeal colored, and dark fitted trousers, her hair down. She had the necklace on, the gold chain visible above the turtleneck.

I watched her cross the patio and say something to Britt near the door, then move toward Jason's end. Paul saw her coming and said something and Jason looked over his shoulder and said something back. When she got to the chairs there was a brief pause in the physical arrangement.

Then she came down to sit sideways across Jason's lap.

It happened simply, the way things happen that have happened before. She came to the chair, there was no adjacent seat, and she sat across him with her legs down between his knees and her back at a slight angle, one shoulder toward his chest. Jason received her without shifting or adjusting his posture, his arm coming around her waist naturally, and the conversation with Paul and Desmond continued without pausing.

I kept talking to Frank.

The patio heater above them glowed orange and made the air around that end of the group warmer than where I was standing. I could see them clearly from across the patio, Jenna with her legs over his thigh talking to Cara, who had pulled a footstool close, Jason talking to Desmond with the focused attention he gave potential clients.

Somewhere in the next twenty minutes his hands moved under her sweater.

It wasn't immediate and I couldn't tell the specific moment because Frank was asking me something about load calculations and I was answering him. But the next time I had a clear sightline to their chair Jason's forearms disappeared beneath the hem of Jenna's turtleneck, the fabric bunched over his wrists. The shape of his hands visible at her waist and lower stomach moving slowly in the absent way his hands moved on the workshop bench.

Jenna had one hand on Jason's shoulder while Cara talked and her other hand rested on the outside of the chair arm. She was looking at Cara and nodding at whatever Cara was saying, also paying no attention to Jason's hand under her top.

Cara was talking about kitchen tile. I could hear the word grout from where I was standing.

Desmond said something to Jason that made Jason laugh and Jason shifted in the chair and Jenna adjusted with his shift without looking away from Cara. They moved together, as one.

Frank said, "You following me?" and I said, "Grout, yeah, sorry, go ahead."

Jason was slowly rubbing Jenna's bare back, high up, low down, all over.

Jason did Christmas the way he did everything, thoroughly and without apparent effort. The house had lights along every roofline and wrapped around the porch columns. There was a tree in the living room that touched the ceiling with ornaments that matched and a wreath on the front door with a real ribbon. It smelled like pine when you walked in and the playlist had Christmas music threaded through it without being overwhelming.

There were thirty-one people. I counted at one point because I needed something to do with my eyes while I was standing near the bookshelf on the far wall. I wasn't talking to anyone. Jenna had spent an age getting ready alone in Jason's bathroom.

She came downstairs at seven forty-five.

The dress was red, fitted from shoulder to hem, the kind of fabric that moves with you when you walk and reflects light when you turn. The hem ended mid-thigh. The platform heels were patent black this time, higher than the cream ones. She'd been practicing to walk in them for three weeks because I'd seen her do it in the basement hallway. Her hair was down and curled in sections that she'd done with the large barrel iron she now kept upstairs, and her lips were a darker red than the dress, glossy, the same lip combination Britt had shown her the night of the concert. The necklace Jason bought her sat on her collarbone above the dress neckline.

She came through the living room and Jason saw her from across it and said, loudly enough for the nearest cluster of people to hear, "There it is," and the cluster all looked. She was stunning, there was no other word for it.

By nine the room had reached the volume and density where individual conversations blurred into general atmosphere. Someone had moved the coffee table and the far end of the living room had become the area where people were dancing the way it happens at good parties, a few people, then more, the music calibrated exactly right for it.

Jason danced the way he moved through rooms, as though the space was already his and everything in it was working with him. He wasn't performing it. He was just good at it the way some people are good at things without studying them.

Jenna stayed in that end of the room.

I watched from the kitchen doorway with Greg, who was telling me something about a property rezoning that I was registering at about forty percent. The other sixty percent was the far end of the living room.

They didn't dance every song together. She danced with Britt for one, with Sonia for part of another. But she came back to Jason's orbit the way a conversation comes back to its main point. And when they were in the same space he moved around her and she moved around him with the easy, calibrated awareness of people who have been in each other's physical space long enough to stop thinking about it.

I was not myself a dancer.

Julius was standing near the tree and I saw him lean toward his wife and say something while looking toward the dancing end of the room. Sonia looked over and then looked at Julius and then her eyes moved to me with an expression that was not quite a smile.

I looked down at my drink.

Paul was next to me at some point and said, "Your girl can really move," and said it genuinely, not carefully, the way you say something you assume everyone present already knows and agrees with.

"Yeah," I said.

At eleven-fifteen Jenna came to find me at the kitchen island. She was bright-eyed and out of breath and she put her hand on my arm and said, "Are you having fun?" and looked at me like the answer would be interesting.

"Good party," I said.

She squeezed my arm, widened her eyes, and went right back toward the music.

Jason's walk-in closet was off the master bedroom and ran deeper than it looked from the door, wide enough for two rails of clothes facing each other with a center island below the mirror, the kind of build-out that took planning and someone who knew what they were doing with a tape measure and a week of uninterrupted work. He'd done it himself, or mostly himself, the way he did most things in the house.

I was coming down the upstairs hallway toward the bathroom when I heard Jenna's voice from behind the master bedroom door, which was pushed partway open. I wasn't heading toward it but the hallway ran past it and the voice was clear through the gap.

"That's too much," she was saying.

"It's not too much," Jason said.

"Jason, that's..."

"Try the jacket first, then tell me it's too much."

I slowed without meaning to.

The bedroom was empty from what I could see through the gap, bed made, curtains open, afternoon light across the floor. The voices were coming from further in, from the closet, which had its own light and whose open door was visible at the far side of the room.

I pushed the bedroom door a few inches and stopped.

From that angle I could see into the closet clearly.

There were clothes on both sides of the center island, five or six pieces on the right-hand rail, tags still attached, a shopping bag from the boutique on Fourth folded on the island counter beside two shoeboxes.

Jenna stood in the center of the closet in front of the mirror in a dark wrap dress, very short, the kind of fabric that drapes rather than clings but does both depending on how you move. She had the dress on but the shoes not yet. She had the dress she'd arrived in, a knit top and jeans, on the island beside the shopping bag.

Jason was crouched in front of her on one knee, holding a heel, black, strappy, a platform, with the ankle strap open in his hand. He tapped her ankle with two fingers and she lifted her foot and he guided the shoe on and threaded the strap through the buckle.

Jenna had one hand on his shoulder for balance, fingers resting there, her eyes on the mirror rather than on him, watching her own reflection as the heel changed her height.

He fastened the strap and tapped her ankle again and she set that foot down and lifted the other and he worked the second shoe the same way, unhurried.

When both were on he stayed crouched for a moment and looked at her feet and closed his hands around her ankles, then up around her calves, and then he stood.

She was looking at herself in the mirror with both hands moving to the wrap of the dress at her waist, adjusting the angle of it. The heels were the same height as the black ones from the Christmas party and they changed the dress completely, the hemline moved two inches higher when she stood at full height.

"Okay," she said, to the mirror.

"Yeah," Jason said, to the same mirror.

He reached past her to the right-hand rail and unhooked the jacket, short, leather, dark brown, and held it open for her and she slipped her arms back into it and he settled it on her shoulders from behind, his hands smoothing the shoulders once on each side before dropping away.

She looked at herself in the jacket and dress and heels. She turned left and then right.

"Where are we even wearing this one this time?" she said.

"Rooftop thing in March," he said. "And the Desmond dinner if that comes through."

She nodded at the mirror slowly, taking it in.

I was standing in the doorway of the bedroom with my hand on the doorframe.

I went to the bathroom and ran the tap and stood over the sink for a moment looking at the drain, then shut the water off and went back downstairs.

When she finally came down, she was back in her original clothes.

“He get you new things again?”

“The man is crazy,” she said, rolling her eyes and shaking her head.

“How many is that?”

“Who knows, he likes to keep my things up in his bedroom. The nice things anyway.”

“Don’t you think this is going too far?”

She laughed and plopped down beside me on the couch as though exhausted. “Yes I think it’s going too far. You need to talk to him, please!” she said and she laughed like it was a good joke. “He seems to have an unlimited budget for my sartorial well being,” she said in mock classy tone.

“He’s always got his hands on you,” I said.

She turned to me and examined both my eyes in turn with a shocked smile on her face. “Are you jealous?” she said. She lifted herself to come down on me and straddled my lap, draping her arms around my shoulders. “You know we’re just having fun with it, right?” She leaned down to touch my lips with hers. “He keeps calling me your girlfriend, don’t you think that means something?”

“It’s just getting a little much,” I said.

“He’s just this way with everybody, he’s one of those big goofy physical guys, they always get whatever they want, don’t they,” she said and she grinned with a shaking head. She kissed me more deeper this time. “Don’t worry, poopsie, he knows about you. It’s just playing around, you know what already.”

The Desmond dinner came through and brought twelve people back to the house afterward for what Jason called a nightcap and what became two more hours of the kind of conversation that runs on its own energy once it gets going, Desmond was good company, his wife was better, and there were four other couples whose names I assembled gradually over the course of the evening.

I was tired by eleven-thirty but the party was still going and I'd learned enough about Jason's gatherings by then to know that leaving early read as something, so I stayed and talked to Frank, who had showed up for the

post-dinner part with his wife, and to a man named David who was a structural engineer who had a running professional relationship with Jason that had apparently produced some results.

By twelve-fifteen people were finding their coats.

It took another thirty minutes for the room to clear, the slow dispersal of the final cluster, the lingering goodbyes at the door, the last five minutes where two people are always still finding something to finish saying.

Jason was at the door saying goodbye to Desmond and his wife. I heard the front door close and then the quiet, relative to the previous three hours.

I carried glasses to the kitchen and wiped down the counter and put away bottles the way I did after most of Jason's gatherings, the minor cleanup that happened before the real cleanup in the morning.

I put the last glasses in the machine and went to look for them in the living room.

The lights were on very low. The playlist had shifted to something slow and spare.

Jason was on the sectional, in the corner section, the wide end, jacket off and top button open, leaning back against the cushions at an angle that was most of the way to horizontal. His phone was face-down on the cushion beside him.

Jenna was on the sectional beside him. It was nearly impossible to see them.

She was kneeling sideways, her knees pulled up on the cushion, her body angled toward him. She had the wrap dress on, the dark one from the closet, but the jacket was gone. The black heels were gone, too. She was barefoot.

And when my eyes adjusted, I saw her right hand inside the front of his jeans.

It wasn't at the waistband, it was inside and deep down, her wrist disappearing too, the shape of her hand visible through the fabric just below his waistline. Her arm was relaxed, not urgent, the position of something ongoing rather than beginning.

Jason was looking at her and saying something quietly and Jenna was looking back at him with her lips apart and a small private expression that I recognized the architecture of even though I had not seen it directed somewhere else before.

She said something back. He smiled, not the wide social smile he used in a room full of people, something smaller and more contained, and he

reached up with one hand and moved a piece of her hair off her shoulder.

I remained standing at the edge of the living room unseen and unnoticed.

Neither of them had heard me come in because the carpet in the living room ran to the edge of the kitchen threshold and my socks on it made no sound.

I stood there for four or five seconds. Then Jason's eyes moved and found me across the room. He looked at me with an expression that didn't change, not surprised, not shifting, simply acknowledging that I was there the way you acknowledge something you've been expecting.

Jenna felt the change in his attention and turned her head and looked at me over her shoulder.

She didn't move her hand.

She looked at me for a moment with an expression I couldn't make into something readable, and then she looked back at Jason slowly, and said something to him quietly that I couldn't hear.

I turned and went back to the kitchen and stood at the counter.

A few minutes later they both came in and got busy silently finishing up the tidying.

Julius had a friend named Cole who kept a boat at the marina on the east end of the lake and who extended the invitation through a chain of people that eventually included everyone who regularly came to Jason's house, which meant by the time the Saturday arrived there were eleven of us at the dock at ten in the morning with a cooler and a bag of food that Jenna and Jason had packed together in the kitchen before I came upstairs.

The boat was a large open-bow with a sun platform at the front and a wide stern seating area and enough deck space in between that people could move around without negotiating. Cole captained and Julius sat up front with him and the rest of us distributed across the rear and the bow.

Jason took the sun platform at the front with the ease of someone who always took the best position without making it seem claimed. He spread a towel and sat with his back against the bow rail and his face toward the sun before we'd cleared the marina.

Jenna went to the front of the boat too.

She had on a white bikini this time, different from the black one, with a thin gold chain around her waist that I hadn't seen before and that matched the necklace. She'd stopped wearing cover-ups somewhere in the last month

of pool gatherings. She settled onto the platform beside Jason with her back against the bow rail mirroring his position. Their shoulders were touching from the time we cleared the no-wake zone until we reached the open water.

I sat in the stern with Greg and a man named Phil whose presence I couldn't account for but who turned out to know Cole from a fishing trip two years back. Greg was good company. Phil was also good company once he relaxed. The water was flat and the speed was good and there was enough wind that conversation required some effort, which made the silences comfortable rather than empty.

I watched the bow platform at intervals.

By noon Jenna was lying on her back on the sun platform with her forearm over her eyes, fully horizontal. Jason was sitting upright beside her with one knee bent, talking to Julius who had come back from the captain's area to eat. His hand was on Jenna's shin, not moving, just resting there.

Cole anchored in a cove around one-thirty. People moved around the boat more once it stopped, in and out of the water, shifting positions. I went in the water and came back and towed off and ate and talked to Phil about something to do with outboard engines that I knew nothing about.

The sun was high and direct and everyone was flattening out on whatever surface they found.

I looked toward the bow.

Jenna was reclined on the platform cushions on her stomach, chin on her folded arms, eyes closed. The bikini ties at her back were untied, the strings lying flat on either side. Jason sat beside her cross-legged with a bottle of sunscreen. He had dispensed some into his palm and was working it into the backs of her thighs with both hands, long slow passes from behind her knee to the lower edge of the bikini bottom, his thumbs occasionally pressing into the center of the muscle the way someone does when they know the geography of what they're touching.

Jenna's eyes remained closed.

At the stern Cole was telling a story about a water ski accident that had Greg laughing hard.

I looked at the water. It was very clear this close to shore and I could see the bottom, which was sandy and even with occasional dark patches where the vegetation grew up through it.

Phil said something and I turned back. Jason was now rubbing sunscreen into Jenna's bare back where the top straps were missing. He cleared her

hair out of the way and ran his fingers around her sides, and over the bulges of the sides of her breasts.

She wasn't reacting in any way.

I waited until Jason was outside before I said anything. He'd gone to check on the patio setup for the evening and I could hear him out there moving chairs, the scrape of the iron legs on the concrete.

Jenna was at the kitchen island putting her earrings in, the gold hoops, Britt's original ones that had migrated permanently into her jewelry collection. She had on the dark wrap dress again, the one from the closet, and the black heels. Her hair was down and finished and her makeup was done and she was essentially ready for the party except for the earrings.

I came to the other side of the island.

"I want to talk about the party," I said.

She looked up from the earring. "What about it?"

"What I walked in on."

She got the backing onto the first earring and started on the second. "We were just sitting on the couch."

"Jenna."

"We were relaxing after the party. It was late."

I kept my voice level. "That's not what I saw."

She set the second earring backing down on the counter and looked at me with an expression that was impatient. It was the expression of someone who has thought about how this conversation would go and is now watching it go that way.

"Chris," she said. "Relax. Everybody knows we're close. It's not a big thing."

"Everybody knows?"

"People here, yes. It's not anything, it's just how things are around here. It's his house. It's his whole social thing, everyone is like that with each other."

"No they're not," I said.

She picked up the second earring and put it in and adjusted it in the mirror of her phone camera. "You're reading into it too much."

"I'm not reading into it."

She set her phone down and looked at me directly. "What do you want me to say?"

"I want you to tell me what's going on."

"Nothing is going on." She said it evenly, without heat, which was somehow harder to respond to than if she'd said it with one or the other. "We live here. He's around all the time. We're comfortable around each other. It's natural."

"There's a difference between comfortable and ..."

"And what?"

The back door opened and Jason came in from the patio, running a hand through his hair, already scanning the kitchen for something. He went to the counter and picked up his phone and looked at the screen and then set it back down.

"People are going to start showing up in twenty," he said.

Jenna turned back to the island and picked up her lip liner and leaned toward the small mirror she had near the fruit bowl.

I stood at the other side of the island.

Jason opened the fridge and got a water and looked at Jenna's reflection in the small mirror and said, "Wear your hair up tonight for me? Sonia said they're doing photos."

Jenna looked at her own reflection for a moment and then set the lip liner down and reached up and dutifully gathered her hair at the back of her neck with both hands.

"Like this?" she said.

He looked at her from across the kitchen. "Yeah. With the piece at the front. Fucking beautiful. Isn't she fucking beautiful?" he said to me.

She adjusted it, pulling a section loose at her temple. "Like this?"

"That's it."

She looked at herself and nodded and then let it all fall back down and went back to the lip liner. "I'll do it before they get here."

Jason took a drink of water and put the bottle on the counter and went back outside.

I was still standing at the island.

Jenna finished the lip liner and pressed her lips together and looked at the result.

"I need to finish getting ready," she said.

The summer party was the biggest Jason had held since we moved in, close to forty people, the backyard fully set up with the catering table and

the pool open and the string lights on even though it was still light out. It was the kind of gathering where the guest list had expanded past the regular core into wider social circles that connected to Jason's business and to Paul's network and to people Desmond apparently knew who knew other people.

I didn't know at least half the people there and spent the first two hours moving through conversations the way you do at large gatherings, surface only, a few exchanges, a natural end point, move to the next cluster. I was good at it when I needed to be and tonight I needed to be.

Jenna was in the backyard most of the evening in a short white sundress Jason had picked up from the boutique, thin-strapped, with the gold chain at her waist visible beneath the fabric when the light hit it right. The platform sandals were the nude ones that added height without being obvious about it. Her hair was up the way Jason had suggested, loose enough at the front to not read as formal.

She moved through the party with a comfort that had no residue of the woman who stayed close to my arm at the first barbecue. She knew names. She touched arms. She laughed first rather than waiting to see if something was funny.

I tracked her at intervals without making it the thing I was doing.

Around nine-thirty I was at the far end of the patio with Frank and a woman named Rachel who was an architect Jason had worked with on the Desmond project. The conversation was good, Rachel had opinions about residential renovation that Frank disagreed with professionally and they were both articulate about it, and I was genuinely in it for twenty minutes or so.

When I looked up Jenna was across the pool talking to Britt and Sonia, the three of them in a close cluster with drinks, easy and familiar. Jason was near the catering table talking to two men I didn't recognize.

Ten minutes later I looked up again and Jenna was not where she had been.

I didn't notice it. Large gatherings have their own fluid movement and people cycle between inside and outside constantly and disappearing from one sightline just means you lost them in the current.

I looked for her in the other parts of the yard. Not there.

I went inside. The living room had eight or nine people in it. The kitchen had more. I moved through both but she was not there there.

And neither was Jason anywhere, which was particularly odd because he was seldom absent in any way from his own parties.

Julius was near the kitchen island and I stopped beside him and he handed me a drink and said, "Good turnout tonight."

"Yeah," I said.

He was quiet for a moment and we both looked at the room.

"They went upstairs a little while ago," he said. He said it at the same volume as everything else, looking at the kitchen and not at me, the way someone delivers information they've decided to deliver.

I looked at the ceiling.

The music from outside was loud enough to come through the walls. The ceiling was quiet. I stood at the kitchen island and drank what Julius had handed me.

Britt came through the sliding door and past us toward the sink and stopped when she saw me. She met my eyes for a moment with an expression I couldn't interpret quickly enough, and then she said, "Have you seen the guacamole? I thought there was a second one."

"I think it's on the catering table," I said.

"Outside? Okay." She refilled her glass and went back out.

Sonia was visible through the sliding door, standing near the pool talking to Rachel.

I stood at the island.

Twenty minutes passed.

Then the stairs creaked and Jenna came around the corner into the kitchen first with her hair down now, loose, and the sundress smooth and her sandals in her hand.

She saw me at the island.

"Hey," she said. "I was looking all over for you."

Jason came down the stairs a moment later.

"Your shoes again," I said.

She shrugged looking down as though only noticing her bare feet then too. "Help me?" she said and she handed me her shows and put her hand on my shoulder knowing I would go down on my knee.

It was a Tuesday evening with no party and no guests and no occasion, which had become the rarest kind of evening in the house since we moved in. Jason was home from a job site by six. I was home by six-thirty. Jenna

had been upstairs most of the afternoon, which had become the pattern. She spent more time on the main floor than in the basement suite now, in the way that happens when one space starts to feel more like where you live than the other.

I came upstairs at eight to tell Jenna that I was thinking about ordering food, that I hadn't eaten and assumed she hadn't either and wanted to know if she wanted anything.

The main floor was quiet. The kitchen was clean. The television in the living room was on low with nobody watching it, a nature documentary, something aerial and green.

I called her name once. Nothing.

I went down the hall toward the bathroom because the light was on underneath the door and I raised my hand to knock. The door was not fully latched and my knock pushed it open two or three inches and I stopped.

The vanity lights were all on. The room was bright and warm.

Jenna was sitting on the edge of the counter beside the sink, her legs hanging. She had on the short dark dress, the wrap one, the one she'd been wearing more, and her heels were off, feet bare against the cabinet below. Her hair was down.

Jason was standing directly in front of her. And they were kissing.

It wasn't urgent and it was not with the compressed energy of something interrupted. It was slow, the pace of something that had been going on for a while. His right hand was on the counter beside her hip and his left hand was beneath the hem of her dress, his forearm disappearing into the fabric at the front, his shoulder moving in that small way that indicates a hand moving somewhere inside clothing.

Jenna's left hand was on the back of his neck, gripping him there. Her right hand was at his chest, fingers spread, her eyes closed.

I stood in the two-inch gap in the door.

Jason sensed it first, or heard the push of the door, the slight change in the air from the hall. He turned his head away from her incrementally, not breaking sharply, just redirecting his attention.

He looked at the door. His expression did not alter in any way. He looked through the gap and at me and then looked back at Jenna, who had felt his attention move and opened her eyes.

She looked at the door too and she looked at me.

The hand on the back of his neck slid forward to his shoulder and rested there. She looked at me with an expression that contained not guilt exactly and not surprise, but something that recognized the moment without trying to resolve it.

Jason's hand came out from beneath the hem of her dress slowly. He set both hands on the counter on either side of her, bracketing her, and he straightened up from the angle he'd been at, unhurried.

Nobody said anything yet.

Jenna's legs were still hanging off the counter edge. The necklace was visible at her collarbone above the neckline of the dress.

Jason turned from the counter and ran the tap and dried his hands on the towel on the ring beside the mirror. He looked at his own reflection once, combed his hair with his fingers, and then turned and moved toward the door.

I stepped back from it.

He came through the gap and into the hallway and passed me with a hand on my shoulder, one firm contact, not apologetic, not aggressive, and he went down the hall toward his bedroom.

Jenna's head hung but she looked up through strands of fallen hair and bit her lip looking at me.

"It's not what it looks like," she said. "We're just really good friends."

Jason started his setup at nine in the morning. I heard him above me moving furniture, the low bass drag of the sectional being repositioned, and by ten I came upstairs and found he'd rearranged the entire living room to face the television at a new angle with the sectional as the centerpiece and folding chairs in a second row behind it and the dining table pushed against the wall to serve as the food station.

By noon the food was arriving in stages, a catering order Jason had placed three days earlier, trays of wings and sliders and things in foil that went directly into the oven on a rotating schedule. The kitchen smelled like it did at the biggest gatherings. The first guests were already arriving while the second half of the pregame was still running.

By kickoff there were thirty-six people in the house.

I found a seat on a section of the sectional, middle of the second row, with Greg on my left and Frank on my right. It was a good seat for the television and a good seat for the room. I could see most of it.

Jenna came out of Jason's bedroom, which I registered without reacting to, at five minutes to kickoff in dark jogger-style pants and a fitted cream ribbed top, the kind of simple comfortable outfit she'd have worn to the very first football Sunday months ago except that it fit differently, or she wore it differently. Her hair was loose and she had just enough on her face to look finished without looking dressed up. The necklace was there.

She came into the living room to a small collective acknowledgment, a few greetings called from various seats, Britt waving from the far end of the sectional, Sonia patting the cushion beside her until Jenna shook her head with a smile and moved toward the main section.

Jason was in the corner of the sectional, the wide end, the host position he always took, with his arm along the back of it and a drink on the side table and the expression of someone who has organized something large and can now be inside it rather than running it.

Jenna sat beside him and curled her legs up onto the cushion and leaned into his side. He put his arm down from the back of the sectional around her without looking away from the screen where the coin toss was happening.

The game started.

I watched both things, the game and the room.

When Desmond arrived late in the first quarter and came through looking for somewhere to sit, it was Jenna who caught his eye and pointed to the space on Jason's other side and said, "There's room," and Desmond came and took it the way you take a seat offered by the person who runs the couch.

When the food needed managing it was Jenna who gave Jason a quick kiss on the lips and got up and went to the kitchen and came back with the next tray and set it on the dining table and told the room it was ready. Everybody received this as information from the person in charge.

During a commercial break a woman I hadn't seen before, someone from Desmond's side, young, clearly new to the group, leaned over to Britt and said something with her eyes moving between Jason and Jenna, and Britt said something back and the woman nodded and looked at them and said, "They're such a good match," in the uncomplicated tone of someone stating something obvious about people they just met.

Britt's eyes came to me and moved away again.

I was looking at the television.

Greg offered me a wing from the tray on his lap and I took it. Frank said something about the defensive coverage and I said something back. The room was very loud on the big plays and very quiet on the bad ones and in the quiet moments I could hear Jason murmuring things to Jenna in the lower register he used when he was talking to just her. Her responses were in small sounds that meant she was laughing without quite laughing. He kissed the side of her neck and she stretched it up for more.

At halftime Jason stood to organize the food and Jenna stayed curled in the warm space his body left in the cushion beside her.

I looked at her and she smiled pleasantly and waved with a small fluttering of her fingers and she scrunched up her shoulders and clenched her eyes to tell me she was loving it.

The cleanup after a thirty-six person Super Bowl party had its own particular quality, the archaeology of an evening in layers, cups and plates and napkins distributed across every horizontal surface in the house including two windowsills and the top of the bookshelf where someone had left an entire plate of wings.

Jason went to drop Desmond and his wife back to their hotel because Desmond had come without a car. Jenna was in the kitchen when I came up from the basement with a garbage bag. She had the radio on low and was moving around the kitchen island methodically.

She had on one of Jason's flannels. The sleeves were rolled twice because they were too long otherwise. She didn't look up when I came in.

I started on the living room.

It took twenty minutes to get the main floor to a state that was manageable. I brought three full bags to the garage recycling and came back each time to Jenna in a more complete kitchen, the surfaces clearing in sections from left to right the way she worked.

A man named Rourke was still there.

I hadn't known his name was Rourke until late in the game when Greg introduced us. He was in his mid-forties, broad, with the easy sociability of a man who had been comfortable in rooms full of people. He worked in the same commercial real estate space as Desmond and had apparently been coming to Jason's gatherings for two years before I'd moved in. He was finishing a last beer at the kitchen island when I brought in the third garbage bag.

He and Jenna were talking when I came in. Something about the game, the fourth quarter specifically, a call that had divided the room. Jenna was at the cabinet putting wine glasses away one at a time, not looking at him, but engaged in the conversation, and Rourke was on the stool with his beer making the case for the call in the patient way of someone who had made it three times already that evening to different audiences.

I started consolidating the bottles on the counter.

Rourke looked over at me and said, "You see that call in the fourth?" I said I did and gave an opinion on it and he received it and redirected toward me, expanding the conversation to include me.

We talked about the game for a few minutes. Jenna kept putting glasses away near us.

Then Rourke said, in the same conversational register, transitioning between topics the way the evening had made easy, "Jason's girl was telling me you two are doing the east end building next, the commercial one."

He was looking at me when he said it.

I held two empty bottles by their necks in my right hand.

Rourke meant Jenna. He was looking at me and he had just been talking to Jenna and he meant Jenna,

"The east end thing, yeah," I said. "I think that's the plan."

Rourke nodded and said something about the timeline and I responded. We talked for another minute and he finished his beer and said his goodbyes and found his jacket somewhere in the living room and let himself out.

The kitchen went quiet.

Jenna reached up and put the last wine glass on the upper shelf. Both arms up, the flannel riding up over the gold chain at her waist. She set the glass in its place and brought her arms down.

I stood there with the two bottles in my hand. "Jenna..."

"Oh god, Chris, can we just not? Soo tired!"

The last guests left at one-fifteen. I heard the front door from the basement and then the house settling.

I came downstairs at eleven and changed into sweats and sat on the basement couch with the television on low and watched something I couldn't have described afterward if asked. I had had enough of the party upstairs.

The basement door opened at one-thirty.

Jenna came down the stairs in another of Jason's shirts, a white fitted one. This one came to mid-thigh. She had nothing on underneath that I could see and her feet were bare on the basement stairs.

She didn't look surprised to find me on the couch. She looked like she'd known I was there before she came down.

"Hey," she said.

"Hey," I said.

She went to the dresser and opened the opened her drawer. She pulled out a pair of her small cotton shorts and a top and set them on the dresser surface.

Then she went to the bathroom.

I heard her moving in there, the cabinet above the sink opening and closing. She came back out with her makeup bag and set it on the dresser beside the clothes. Then she went to the closet and took out her overnight bag, small, canvas, olive green, the one she used for weekends away, and opened it on the bed.

She put the clothes in first. Then the makeup bag. She went back to the bathroom and came out with her face wash and her moisturizer and her toothbrush in a travel case and put those in next. Then she went back to the dresser for the small perfume she kept there.

I watched her pack from the couch.

Above us the music was still playing, faint through the ceiling, something slow, the kind of playlist that runs after a party winds down. I could hear it and not hear it depending on how I was breathing.

Jenna zipped the bag and straightened up.

She looked at me then, directly, and for the first time since she came downstairs. Her hair was loose and her face was clean, no makeup, the way she looked in the mornings before she started using Jason's bathroom. It was closer to how she looked the day we moved in than she had looked in weeks.

"I'm gonna need something in the morning," she said with a shrug, pointing at the bag she just packed. "I have an early thing Jason has offered to drive me to."

I looked at the bag.

"Okay," I said.

She picked the bag up by the strap and held it at her side. She stood there a moment like she was deciding something.

“So... goodnight, Chris, I guess,” she said. “I think I’m going to sleep up there tonight. It’ll be easier that way, right? Won’t wake you up.”

Her voice was even and clear and not even unkind.

She went up the stairs and gave me another of those small fluttering finger waves she was giving me lately, small private secret and nearly apologetic waves.

The door at the top opened and the music came through brighter for a moment, and I heard Jason say something and her laugh in response, a short, surprised one.

And then the door closed and the music receded back to something I could hear only if I was listening for it.